minimize waste and maximize reuse and recycling, and to develop “clean” waste disposal systems.

In the last decades of the 20th century, it had become clear that refuse was reaching unmanageable proportions. Industrialization, the growth of large urban populations, and increasing use of plastic were all adding to the world’s garbage heap. Traditionally waste had been burned or buried, both options now associated with toxic greenhouse gas emissions and, in the case of landfills, the potential for poisoning ground water. The answer to the world’s growing waste heap had to be found elsewhere.

“Pollution is nothing but the resources we are not harvesting. We allow them to be dispersed because we’ve been ignorant of their value.”

R. Buckminster Fuller

American inventor and architect

The recycling revolution

Recycling for reuse is not a new concept, but its use as a way of reducing mountains of public waste that would otherwise go into landfill has its origins in the 1960s and 1970s, when organizations such as Greenpeace made the public more aware of environmental issues. Recently, campaigners such as Paul Connett, author of *Zero Waste* (2013), have renewed global calls to reduce consumption, and reuse or recycle items, rather than discard them.

Since the 1970s, many US states and most European countries, as well as Canada, Australia, and New Zealand, have introduced curbside collections of recyclable items sorted into bins. Sweden has been especially active. In 1975, Swedes recycled only 38 percent of their rubbish, but today they lead the world, recycling 99 percent of household waste. About 50 percent of this waste is burned in recycling plants that generate heat for the nation’s homes. Sweden also imports waste from other countries to process in its 34